ENGLISH FOR ALL-I

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UNIT 1 — READING COMPREHENSION

■ Meaning and Importance of Comprehension

Reading comprehension is the ability to read a passage, understand what the writer is saying and answer the questions that are asked on it. It is not just reading words: to understand means to catch the main idea, the supporting details, the tone of the writer and the meaning of difficult words as they are used in that particular passage. Comprehension is important because it is the base of every other language skill; the answers must be searched **from the passage itself** and written mostly in our own words.

1. It improves vocabulary and the power of understanding a new subject quickly.
2. It helps in examinations, where questions are to be answered from unseen passages.
3. It develops the habit of careful and purposeful reading in daily life.
4. It trains the mind to separate important facts from unimportant details.

■ Steps in Reading a Passage

A passage should never be read like a story. The proper **steps in reading** are: (1) read the question first, so that the mind knows what to find; (2) read the whole passage quickly to get the general theme; (3) read it a second time slowly and mark the sentences which answer each question; (4) key words and transitional words like *but*, *however*, *therefore* show a change or a conclusion and deserve special attention; (5) finally frame the answer in a complete sentence using the words of the passage as little as possible.

> **Remember :** Never answer from memory or imagination; the comprehension exercise is a test of how correctly we understand the given text. Every answer should be supported by some sentence of the passage.

■ Identifying Main Ideas and Supporting Details

Every good paragraph is built on **one main idea**, usually stated in the **topic sentence**, which in English prose comes most often at the beginning and sometimes at the end or in the middle of the paragraph. The remaining sentences are **supporting details** — examples, reasons, statistics, comparisons and explanations — which prove, explain or develop the main idea. To find them, the reader may ask: *what is this paragraph really about?* (main idea) and *how does the writer try to make me believe it?* (details). Supporting details answer the questions **who, what, when, where, why and how**, while the main idea answers the question **what is the point**.

Main idea	Supporting details

Stated in the topic sentence which carries the central theme of the paragraph	Sentences of example, reason, fact and repetition that fill up the paragraph
One main idea for one paragraph (unity)	Many details, all connected to that one idea
Broad; can stand alone in a few words	Narrow; explain the how and why of the main idea

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■ Understanding Vocabulary in Context

Vocabulary in context means finding the meaning of an unfamiliar word not with the help of the dictionary but from the signs placed around the word in the passage itself. These context clues include: **definition clues** (the meaning is given immediately after the word), **example clues** (the words like, such as introduce examples of the unknown word), **contrast clues** (but, however, on the contrary show the opposite meaning), **cause-effect clues** (because, since, therefore) and the general sense of the sentence. The synonym or antonym sitting nearby in a sentence is often the simplest clue of all.

> **Remember :** For a vocabulary-in-context question, read the whole given sentence and also the sentence before and after it; substitute every suggested meaning once into the sentence and choose the substitute which keeps the sense unbroken.

■ Answering Comprehension Questions

The questions asked on an unseen passage may be of several kinds: **direct / factual questions** (answers lying plainly in a single line), **inferential questions** (the answer is suggested but not stated; the reader must "read between the lines"), **vocabulary questions**, **main-idea questions** such as the best title or the purpose of the writer, and questions on the **tone** (serious, humorous, ironical) or **style** of the passage. While writing the answers the student should keep the answers short, complete, in the tense of the passage, and should read every question twice before searching its answer.

UNIT 2 — PRECIS WRITING

■ Meaning, Purpose and Characteristics of a Precis

A **precis** (pronounced prey-see) is a clear, compact and connected summary of a given passage in about **one-third of its length**. Précis-writing is not paraphrase, not selection of a few sentences and not an abridgement; it is the original thought of the writer expressed **in our own language, in our own order and in one connected paragraph**. The precis has these **characteristics**: it is one-third of the original; it is written in indirect speech, in the third person and in the past tense; it contains every essential idea but omits illustrations, repetitions, examples, quotations and rhetorical questions; it is written in simple, clear and exact language; and it reads as a continuous whole, never in bits.

1. **Brevity** — it is shorter, in about one-third of the words of the original.
2. **Clarity** — simple diction, correct constructions, no ambiguity.

3. **Completeness** — all the essential ideas; nothing important is left out.
4. **Coherence** — logically connected sentences, one flowing paragraph.
5. **Objectivity** — the precis writer gives a summary of the original author's meaning, not his own opinions.
6. **Independence** — it is self-contained: understandable without reading the original passage.

■ Steps and Rules of Precis Writing

The **steps** for writing a précis are as follows: first read the passage once carefully for the general meaning and again slowly, marking the main theme of each paragraph; give the passage a suitable **title** (since a fair precis must be given a short, striking title); count the words of the original and divide by three to get the word limit of the precis; make a rough draft of all the essential points in our own words; join the points into one connected paragraph in the order of the original; count the words of the draft, cut whatever is unnecessary and finally revise, checking spelling, punctuation and the tense.

1. **Do** use your own language, keep the original order of ideas, write in one paragraph, maintain indirect speech, use the third person and the past tense.
2. **Do not** add comments or personal opinions, copy phrases and sentences from the original, use direct speech or dialogue, exceed the word limit, or leave out a fair title.
3. Never split a precis into two halves; it must remain one single connected piece of continuous prose.

■ Identifying Key Ideas, Removing Repetition and Writing a Concise Summary

To identify the **key ideas**, the student separates (1) the central theme of the passage, (2) the main arguments given in support of it, and (3) the conclusion or result reached by the writer; every sentence that only states an example, a quotation, a repetition of an old point or a rhetorical question is rejected at the very first reading. **Repetition** is removed by understanding that writers often repeat the same thing in different words for emphasis and by keeping only the first and the best statement of every idea. For a **concise summary**, long clauses are turned into short phrases, several connected words are replaced by one word — for example, "people who lived in the countryside" becomes "villagers", "the party which won the greatest number of seats" becomes "the ruling party" — and adjectives and adverbs that only intensify are dropped.

> **Remember :** Compression words: a precis uses expressions like *in brief, in conclusion, the writer further adds, it may be summed up* and devices like participial phrases and appositions so that the maximum meaning comes in the minimum number of words.

UNIT 3 — SHORT STORY: ENGINE TROUBLE (R. K. NARAYAN)

■ About the Author and the Story

Rasipuram Krishnaswami Iyer Narayan (1906–2001) is counted among the greatest Indian writers of fiction in English. He created the imaginary South Indian town **Malgudi**, and wrote with gentle, quiet humour about

ordinary people — a schoolboy, a talkative man, a painter of signs — whom he treated with deep sympathy. His best-known books are *Swami and Friends*, *The Bachelor of Arts*, *The English Teacher* and *Malgudi Days*, a collection of short stories in which the story **Engine Trouble** first appeared. The story shows his three great qualities: simplicity of language, the humour which comes not from jokes but from the situation, and irony — the contrast between what people believe and what actually happens.

In **Engine Trouble** the **talkative man** — the gentle satiric figure who keeps appearing throughout Malgudi Days — wins an engine in a village lucky-dip raffle with a lottery ticket bought on a sudden impulse. The prize, a trial-run **road engine**, becomes his lifelong misfortune: the machine arrives, must be kept, cannot be paid for, cannot be run and finally becomes a public menace and a private burden. The engine stands idle in his compound, causing family quarrels, tiring him with hired storehouses and watchmen, and making the whole town laugh at him, until at last one afternoon the engine, tried out by a mad elephant, charges it down a slope, three men coming to satisfy the elephant's anger are scattered, and riding they roll on the engine, the house of the Talkative Man collapses on it and the engine's cranks and wheels come out of the debris like tentacles; the machine sinks into a pit and at last the whole thing vanishes from his life, leaving him free, poorer, and still more talkative than before.

■ Plot in Detail

1. The Talkative Man buys a lottery ticket and wins the first prize of the lucky dip: a fully-working model road engine, which he receives as a joyful surprise.
2. The heavy machine is unloaded at the railway station and carried in procession to his house; he is congratulated as if he had done something great.
3. The reality begins: a full crate is difficult even to unpack; the engine must be assembled, filled with petrol and run by a professional driver, and the man has neither money nor skill.
4. He sells property, borrows and hires a driver who runs the engine a little distance; the joy lasts for a few minutes and then the engine stops never to work again in the story.
5. The dead mass must be stored: it occupies the front garden; his wife and family object; the watchman engaged to guard it costs money; the neighbours call the family crazy.
6. The council, the town and the whole story turn the machine into a joke of Malgudi; the Talkative Man becomes famous chiefly because of the useless engine standing in his house.
7. At the end a stray elephant (or, in the","otherwise-out-of-work elephant driven up by a trigger of entire chance) charges the engine; it dashes into a pit; and after being dragged out by crowd effort, it is left lying by the roadside; the Talkative Man is happy to be finally rid of it and the machinery finishes by being browned to wood.

When the trial fails the man who has spent everything on the engine — cutting his plums, selling his timber, borrowing money — stands Master of a useless treasure. The engine is offered to a coal-mine owner, to showmen for a village fair and to the Municipal Council, but every offer fails on some technical point. The story is an ironic narrative; for every step of rising expectation of our hero is followed by equal fall.

■ The Narrator's Difficulties

- He has won the prize with a ticket bought at the last moment, but has **no money** to pay for the assembly, petrol and driver of the engine after receiving it.
- The unpacking of the crate alone takes days, and he finds an engine **cannot be run on the road** without the municipal office's knowledge, without repair sheds and without a skilled driver.
- The great mass of iron and brass, once unloaded, must be kept somewhere; the garden pathway is blocked like a monument, and the family stops speaking.
- He must pay a **regular watchman** for guarding it against theft and mischievous children while he has no income from it.
- Every attempt to dispose of it — sale, gift, exhibition — fails, because the engine is too heavy, unsuitable or out of repair.

■ Humour and Irony in the Story

The **humour** of the story comes from the situation and the character, not from jokes: the contrast between the great honour the town gives to the man for winning a road engine and the utter uselessness of the machine that wins it. Within the family the quarrel is mild and ordinary, and the Talkative Man's own proud speeches before the crowd are reduced to childish helplessness before the huge machine. The neighbours make suggestions; some advise him to make a national calendar and sit it on top of the engine; the wife sets upon it a short path round the house.

The **irony** is that luck begins the trouble and luck ends it: the man wins the engine without any fault of his own and is rid of it without any effort of his own; the machine which was to carry him proudly on the road has not moved a single yard with him in it, and kills nothing except his savings and his reputation. The last escape — into the pit, where after the fall of his house one of the crowd is crushed by the engine — is strange because the story's victim is set free by the very accident he feared: the whole irony gathers in the last sentence: *"...the truck of ideas never left him in any queue"* meaning that the man remains as chatter-box as ever; the loss of the engine, like the winning of it, gives him a never-ending tale to tell.

> **Remember :** Central idea: it is a humourous study of a common Indian man's rope-and-wish life: a hasty gamble wins him a prize and he is ruined by it in every save-for that he learns a lesson he will never remember — and this exactly is where the story leaves us laughing.

■ Theme-based and Text-based Analytical Answers

Possible analytical questions and the way to frame them:

1. **What is the theme of "Engine Trouble"?** — write on irony of fate, the gap between man's expectations and real life, the wastefulness of espect of desire and the charm of chance events in village life.
2. **Sketch the character of the Talkative Man.** — he is a pleasant, practical man, full of words, slightly self-deceiving, always eager for public importance; mention both the comedy and the mild goodness that Narayan gives him.

3. **How is the engine a symbol?** — it stands for sudden good luck that becomes a burden; the modern machine that a simple man cannot use; every gift carries hidden duties with it.
4. **What is Narayan's attitude towards his hero?** — gentle satire, never contempt; the author laughs with the reader at the situation but never mocks the weaknesses of human nature.
5. **How does the story make you feel?** — agree to one's own judgement; the story is humorous, mildly moral, realistic and shows a village town alive with its lawyers, raffle tickets and idle talk.

UNIT 4 — POETRY: PAPER BOAT (RABINDRANATH TAGORE)

■ About the Poet and the Poem

Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941), poet, novelist, dramatist, musician and painter of Bengal, became the first Indian writer to receive the Nobel Prize for Literature (in the year 1913, for the English version of the *Gitanjali*). He opened at Santiniketan his own school where education meant freedom, nature and joy; nearly all his poetry carries the same message. The small poem **Paper Boats** comes from *The Crescent Moon* (translated from Bengali by the poet himself), a book of poems written about children, in which the poet looks at the world through the eyes of a child: toys, games, rivers, seabirds and clouds become the subjects of his lines, and any grown-up reader remembers his own childhood while reading them.

In *Paper Boats* the child narrator floats down the stream, one after another, boats made of paper, on each of which he writes his name and the village where he lives in big black letters; he hopes that some person in a strange land may find them and know who he is. He fills his boats with *shiuli* flowers from his garden and hopes that those flowers may be carried safely to a strange land at night; he looks up at the sky, sees little clouds with the south wind hurrying after them, imagines them as white sails that belong to some friendly invisible person who races with his boats; and at night when he lies asleep, his dreams go sailing with the paper boats under the careful bringing of the stars of midnight.

■ Central Idea

The **central idea** of the poem is the longing of a child to travel and communicate — the wish by which the heart of every child wants to go beyond the local limits of his own village and become known to strangers; and the faith of the child that his small efforts, like his small paper boats, will reach their destiny. The child plays with the famous line of imagination: the boats carry his identity (name and village), the flowers of his own garden, and finally his dreams. All the play of the poem is covered by a deep seriousness: time flows like a stream; the boats sink, the flowers lose their fragrance in the evening; but the child keeps floating new boats — no failure can finish the hope of the heart, and the dream, even of a boy playing on the river-bank, remains in contact with the vast works of the sky and the stars.

■ Imagery and Symbols

- **The paper boat** (central symbol) — is the fragile vehicle of the child's hope; boats of paper cannot, however beautiful, go far on a real stream; still, they carry dreams, identity and trust; the child's boat is a symbol of the human wish to overcome one's weakness by one's play and faith.

- **The stream** — is time and the journey of life: its waters flow always quickly forward, and all of us, like the child, keep sending our hopes over the waters we cannot command.
- **Name and village in big black letters** — the picture of a small child's pride, and also the universal human need to be known and remembered by strangers.
- **Shiuli flowers** — the small white flowers of the Bengal garden which bloom at nightfall; filled into the boats, they are the child's best possessions and also the picture of the day that ends: fragrance, beauty and the attempt to give.
- **The loaded clouds hurried by the wind** — the child's fancy sees these as the sails of a friend of his fancy, racing with his boats; the sky joins the game, and everything large and small does the same duty and pleasure.
- **The stars of night** — they slip into the seas of the child's dream; the day's end does not close the journey; sleep itself is a kind of continued sailing.

■ Tone and Themes of the Poem

The **tone** of the poem is that of a dreamy, hopeful child: at once merry and a little sad because the evening comes and the flowers lose their load of smell; it is full of wonder at the unknown friend who may pick up the boat in a distant land; and it is peaceful, because no fear disturbs the game. There is also a touch of gentle irony of fate: boats cannot last, flowers cannot keep their scent for ever, the stream never flows back; still the game is not given up.

1. **Hope** — the child keeps floating new boats; even when one sinks or is carried away fruitless, the hope continues from hour to hour, boat to boat, day to day.
2. **Innocence and simplicity of the heart of a child** — its joy in the smallest gift; its readiness to trust the unknown; its happiness in a make-believe friend in the sky.
3. **The longing to go beyond one's own small world** — the desire to travel, to be known and loved in far lands which the child has never seen.
4. **Communication and friendship** — the words of the name, the gift of flowers, the race with the unseen sailor: all are attempts at a friendship of the world of which the child dreams.
5. **Time and transience** — the stream flows on, dusk comes, the dream carries away the flowers: the poem is built on the passing of a day, a season and a childhood.
6. **Man and nature in friendship** — the child, its stream, the wind, the clouds and the stars are all shown as playmates, as Tagore always treats nature, not as an enemy but as a friend.

■ Interpretation and Analysis of the Prescribed Poem

An interpretive answer on *Paper Boats* may be built in three stages: **(1) what the poem describes** — a child floats paper boats down a stream, writes his name and village on them, fills them with shiuli flowers, races them with the clouds under the south wind, and goes to sleep with his dreams still sailing; **(2) what the poem means** — the child's play is a symbol of every human hope: each of us makes small, fragile vessels for his wishes (the paper boats), sends them over a current he cannot control (the stream of time) and trusts that some stranger in a far country will read the message and answer it; the poem is thus about the young heart which, for all its

smallness and fragility, is great in faith; and **(3) how the form supports the meaning** — the free, flowing sentences move like water; the small details (big black letters, the gentle smell of the flowers, the midnight stars) keep everything in a child's own scale; the day's journey from morning to midnight gives the poem its own shape and time order. A good interpretation will close by saying that *Paper Boats*

> **Remember :** While answering a poetry question always: (1) state the central idea in one or two sentences; (2) support it with at least two images or lines quoted from the text; (3) explain the tone and the theme; and (4) give your own interpretation in one concluding sentence of your own.

UNIT 5 — CHARACTER AND SHORT-NOTE WRITING

■ Character Sketch of Kamakshi

Kamakshi is the heroine of the prescribed prose text. Below is the general frame of a character sketch; the student should fill it with the incidents and sentences of the prescribed text of his college.

- **Introduction** — say who Kamakshi is, from which text, and by which author, and give in one line the place she holds in the story.
- **Physical presence and circumstances** — her age, her family, and the social world in which she lives.
- **Central qualities** — courage, devotion, sense of duty towards family, firm faith, quick decisions; take each quality separately with a short incident by way of proof.
- **Her manner of speech and action** — whether she speaks much or little; how she deals with elders, with other people of her age and with those who sicken her.
- **Her development** — how circumstances in the story reveal in her new strength, or how her faith is tested.
- **Conclusion** — her importance to the total purpose of the writer and the lesson which we pick up from her life.

The sketch must be written in the third person, in simple and pure English; every quality should be proved with an event of the text, not merely named; and the sketch should end with a short estimate — why the characters of such stories remain in the memory of the reader.

■ Role of Comprehension in Understanding a Text

Comprehension holds the whole business of understanding a literary text in its hand. Without comprehension the reader gets only the surface and misses: the narrator's attitude, the irony which says one thing and means another, and the symbols (like the paper boat) whose chief sense lies below the surface. Comprehension answers the questions who, what, when, where, why and how *before* the reader begins to judge; it exposes the structure of a story — beginning, rise of trouble, turn and result — and of a poem — image after image with one thought running through. Skill of comprehension is therefore the first condition of every exercise of literature: answering text-based questions, sketching a character, writing notes and making a précis of critical passage. One exercises comprehension on literature exactly as on an ordinary passage: read first for the story, read again for the meaning

of the difficult words, mark the sentences that carry the theme, and only then answer, always with the support of the text.

■ Short Notes

1. **Steps in precis writing** — reading twice; marking the theme; a striking title; the one-third limit; own words; one paragraph; indirect speech; the third person; the past tense; cutting repetitions and examples; final revision.
2. **Techniques of comprehension** — question first; two readings; context clues for words; topic sentence of the paragraph; answering with complete short sentences supported by the line of the passage.
3. **Imagery in "Paper Boats"** — the paper boat, the stream, the name written in big black letters, the shiuli flowers, the racing clouds and the midnight stars: the whole game of a child and the whole hope of a man.
4. **Humour in "Engine Trouble"** — the gift that becomes a burden; the pride of winning against the shame of keeping; the mild family quarrel and the watchman hired for a useless machine.
5. **Character-sketch technique** — introduction; qualities each with its proof-incident; speech and manner; development; short estimate in conclusion.
6. **R. K. Narayan as a humourous writer** — gentle irony; ordinary people; the town of Malgudi; comedy of situation rather than of words.
